Masterkey

The Thousand Oaks

Buyer's Playbook

Your step-by-step guide to buying a home in the Conejo Valley with confidence.

$1.03M	$1.12M	6.0%	70
Median Price Thousand Oaks	Median Price Conejo Valley	Projected Avg Mortgage Rate	Median Days on Market

What's Inside

01 **Why Thousand Oaks?**
What makes the Conejo Valley one of SoCal's best places to buy

02 **2026 Market Snapshot**
Current prices, inventory, and what the numbers mean for you

03 **The Home Buying Process**
Your 8-step roadmap from pre-approval to closing day

04 **Understanding Your Costs**
Down payments, closing costs, and hidden expenses decoded

05 **Neighborhood Guide**
Thousand Oaks vs. Westlake Village vs. Newbury Park vs. Oak Park

06 **Mistakes to Avoid**
The 7 most common (and costly) buyer mistakes in this market

07 **Your Next Steps**
How MasterKey helps you buy with confidence

08 **Meet Your Team**
The people behind MasterKey's technology-driven approach

Why Thousand Oaks?

The Conejo Valley has long been one of Southern California's most sought-after suburban regions. Spanning Thousand Oaks, Westlake Village, Newbury Park, Agoura Hills, and Oak Park, the area consistently ranks among the best places to live in the state. Here's why buyers keep choosing it.

Top-Rated Schools

The Conejo Valley Unified School District is one of the highest-performing districts in Ventura County. Families relocate specifically for access to these schools, which supports long-term property values.

Outdoor Lifestyle

With over 14,000 acres of open space, 75+ miles of hiking trails, and year-round sunshine, the area offers a quality of life that's hard to match. Think Santa Monica Mountains, Wildwood Park, and dozens of community parks.

Proximity to LA

The 101 freeway connects you to the Westside and Downtown LA, while offering the peace of suburban living. Many residents commute to Warner Bros., Disney, and tech companies along the corridor.

Safety and Community

Thousand Oaks consistently ranks among the safest cities in America. Low crime rates, strong neighborhood identity, and active community events make it ideal for families and professionals.

Long-Term Value

Home values in the Conejo Valley have appreciated steadily over the past decade. Even during market corrections, the area's fundamentals (schools, safety, location) protect against steep declines.

MasterKey Insight

Buyers who were priced out during 2021-2022 are finding 2026's balanced market much more approachable. More inventory, less competition, and stabilizing rates mean you can take your time and make informed decisions.

2026 Market Snapshot

Understanding current market conditions is essential before making an offer. Here's where things stand in the Conejo Valley as of early 2026.

$1.03M	70 Days	98.1%	1.9 Mo
Median Price Thousand Oaks	Median Days on Market	Sale-to-List Price Ratio	Months of Supply

Sources: Zillow, Houzeo, California Association of Realtors (data through early 2026)

What Do These Numbers Mean?

Prices are stable. The Thousand Oaks median home price is approximately $1,030,000, up about 3% year-over-year. The broader Conejo Valley sits around $1.1M. Growth has moderated from the pandemic-era spikes, creating a more predictable buying environment.

Inventory is growing. Active listings are up roughly 23% from last year, giving buyers meaningfully more options. This is still well below 2019 levels, but the trend favors buyers.

Homes are taking longer to sell. At 70 days on market (up from 50 last year), there's less urgency to make snap decisions. About 75% of listings have seen at least one price reduction, which signals room to negotiate.

Rates are projected around 6%. The California Association of Realtors expects mortgage rates to average 6.0% in 2026, down from 6.2% recently. Even small rate drops meaningfully increase purchasing power.

2026 Forecast

Industry analysts broadly agree: 2026 is a stabilization year, not a crash year. Home prices in Thousand Oaks are forecast to appreciate 2-4%. California statewide, C.A.R. projects a 3.6% price increase to $905,000 and a 2% rise in sales volume. The market is normalizing after years of constrained supply, not heading toward a bubble burst.

What This Means for You

The 2026 market is the most buyer-friendly environment since before the pandemic. You have more choices, more time to decide, and more negotiation leverage. Waiting for a 'crash' means potentially missing out on today's favorable conditions while competing with sidelined buyers who will flood back when rates drop further.

The Home Buying Process

Buying a home can feel overwhelming, especially if it's your first time. Here's the process broken into 8 clear steps so you always know what comes next.

1

Check Your Financial Health

Review your credit score (aim for 620+ minimum, 740+ for best rates), calculate your debt-to-income ratio, and assess how much you have saved for a down payment. A MasterKey agent can connect you with trusted local lenders to review your options.

2

Get Pre-Approved

A pre-approval letter from a lender shows sellers you're serious and qualified. It also locks in your rate for 60-90 days. In the Conejo Valley, strong pre-approvals still make a difference in competitive situations.

3

Define Your Priorities

Bedrooms, school district, commute time, yard size, single-story vs. two-story, HOA tolerance. Getting clear on your must-haves vs. nice-to-haves prevents decision fatigue once you start touring homes.

4

Tour Homes and Research Neighborhoods

Your MasterKey buyer specialist will set up curated showings based on your criteria. We recommend touring 8-12 homes before making an offer to calibrate your expectations. Drive the neighborhoods at different times of day.

5

Make an Offer

Your agent will run a comparative market analysis (CMA) to determine fair market value, then craft an offer with the right price, contingencies, and terms. In today's market, 98% of homes sell at or slightly below asking, so there's room to negotiate.

6 Enter Escrow and Complete Inspections

Once your offer is accepted, you'll enter escrow (typically 30-45 days). During this period: hire a home inspector ($400-$600), complete the appraisal (ordered by your lender), review all disclosures, and negotiate any repair credits.

7 Finalize Your Loan

Your lender will complete underwriting, order a title search, and prepare closing documents. You'll receive a Closing Disclosure at least 3 business days before closing that details every cost. Review it carefully against your original Loan Estimate.

8 Close and Get Your Keys

Sign the final documents at the title company, wire your closing funds, and the deed is recorded with Ventura County. Congratulations, you're a Conejo Valley homeowner. MasterKey will be there every step of the way and long after you've moved in.

Understanding Your Costs

The purchase price is just one part of the equation. Here's a realistic breakdown of what you'll need to budget when buying in the Conejo Valley.

Down Payment

Loan Type	Minimum Down	On $1M Home	Notes
Conventional	3-5%	**$30K-$50K**	PMI required below 20%
FHA	3.5%	**$35K**	MIP required for life of loan
VA	0%	**$0**	Eligible veterans/active military
Jumbo	10-20%	**$100K-$200K**	Required above conforming limit

Note: The 2026 conforming loan limit for Ventura County is checked annually. Most Conejo Valley purchases above $766,550 may require jumbo financing.

Closing Costs

California buyers typically pay 2-5% of the purchase price in closing costs. On a $1,030,000 home (Thousand Oaks median), that's roughly $20,600 to $51,500. Excluding prepaids like taxes and insurance escrows, the core costs average about 2.1%.

Item	Details	Typical Cost
Escrow fees	Split 50/50 in SoCal	$1,500-$3,000
Title insurance (lender's)	Required by lender	$1,000-$2,500
Title insurance (owner's)	Seller typically pays in SoCal	Seller's cost
Appraisal	Ordered by lender	$500-$800

Home inspection	Strongly recommended	$400-$600
Loan origination fee	0.5-1% of loan amount	$4,000-$8,000
Prepaid taxes and insurance	2-6 months escrowed	$4,000-$12,000
Recording fees	Ventura County	$75-$150

Pro Tip: Negotiate Closing Costs

In today's balanced market, buyers have more leverage to ask for seller concessions. With 75% of listings seeing price reductions, many sellers will contribute toward closing costs to get the deal done. Your MasterKey agent will help you structure this into your offer.

Monthly Payment Estimate

Here's what a typical monthly payment looks like on a $1,030,000 Thousand Oaks home with 20% down at a 6.0% rate (30-year fixed):

Loan amount	$824,000
Principal and interest	$4,941/mo
Property tax (est. 1.1%)	$944/mo
Homeowner's insurance	$250/mo
HOA (if applicable)	$0-$400/mo
Total estimated payment	**$6,135-$6,535/mo**

Neighborhood Guide

The Conejo Valley isn't a monolith. Each community has its own character, price point, and lifestyle. Here's a quick comparison to help narrow your search.

Thousand Oaks

Median: $1.03M

Balanced market

The valley's largest city and commercial center. Excellent schools (CVUSD), abundant parks, shopping at The Oaks and Janss Marketplace. Diverse housing stock from starter condos ($550K) to estates ($3M+). Stabilizing at near-flat year-over-year prices with growing inventory.

Westlake Village

Median: $1.4M+

Buyer-leaning market

The luxury pocket of the Conejo Valley, anchored by Westlake Lake and golf courses. Higher-end homes are taking longer to sell, giving buyers real negotiation room. Highly desirable for executives and families seeking premium amenities.

Newbury Park

Median: $950K

Competitive market

The best value in the valley. Strong appeal for families seeking CVUSD schools at a lower entry point. Updated homes attract steady interest. Proximity to Amgen's campus drives demand from biotech professionals. Well-priced homes still move quickly.

Agoura Hills

Median: $1.1M

Moderate market

Straddling the LA/Ventura county line, Agoura Hills appeals to LA commuters who want suburban space without going too far from the Westside. Close to Malibu Creek State Park. Competitive for well-priced homes, especially those under $1M.

Oak Park

Median: $980K

Stable market

A smaller, tight-knit community known for highly-rated schools (Oak Park USD) and a family-friendly atmosphere. Limited inventory means homes hold value well. Great option for families who prioritize education and community.

7 Mistakes to Avoid

Even in a buyer-friendly market, costly mistakes can derail your purchase. Here are the most common ones we see.

1. **Skipping pre-approval**
   Without a pre-approval letter, sellers won't take your offer seriously. Worse, you might fall in love with a home you can't actually afford. Get pre-approved before you start touring.

2. **House-hunting without a budget for total costs**
   Your monthly payment isn't just principal and interest. Property tax, insurance, HOA fees, and maintenance can add $1,500-$2,000/month on a typical Conejo Valley home. Budget for the full picture.

3. **Waiving the home inspection**
   This was common in the 2021-2022 frenzy. In 2026's balanced market, there's no reason to skip it. A $500 inspection can save you from $50,000 in hidden foundation, roof, or plumbing issues.

4. **Making major purchases before closing**
   Buying a car, opening new credit cards, or making large purchases during escrow can tank your credit score and derail your loan. Keep your finances stable until after you have the keys in hand.

5. **Ignoring the neighborhood**
   A beautiful home in the wrong location is a bad investment. Visit at rush hour. Check school ratings. Walk the neighborhood at night. Talk to future neighbors. Your agent can pull data on pending developments too.

6. **Bidding emotionally**
   In a market where 75% of listings have price reductions, overpaying because you 'fell in love' is avoidable. Trust the comparable sales data. Your MasterKey agent will run a CMA so you offer based on facts, not feelings.

7. **Not understanding contingencies**
   Inspection, appraisal, and loan contingencies protect you. Removing them to 'win' a bidding war (rare in 2026) means you could lose your deposit if something goes wrong. Know what each contingency does before waiving it.

Your Next Steps

You've got the knowledge. Now it's time to put it into action. MasterKey combines expert agents with technology to make your home buying experience seamless, transparent, and confidence-building.

1. **Book a Free Buyer Consultation**
   No pressure, no obligation. We'll review your goals, budget, and timeline, then create a personalized search strategy for the Conejo Valley.

2. **Get Connected with a Trusted Lender**
   We work with local lenders who understand Ventura County properties and can get you pre-approved quickly with competitive rates.

3. **Start Your Curated Home Search**
   Your dedicated buyer specialist will set up custom searches, schedule showings, and guide you through every offer and negotiation.

Meet Your MasterKey Team

MasterKey was built by two brothers who believe buying a home should be powered by technology and guided by expertise. Here's who you'll be working with.

Mark Mathias

Co-Founder / Principal Broker

With a background in SaaS sales leadership and product management, Mark brings a strategic, tech-forward approach to every real estate transaction. His goal: make buying a home in the Conejo Valley feel effortless.

Michael Mathias

Co-Founder / CTO / Broker

Michael's expertise from leading ad-tech platforms for clients like Google and Nike powers MasterKey's technology-driven approach. He ensures every client gets cutting-edge tools and personalized service.

Ready to Find Your Home?

Visit www.usemasterkey.com/contact to schedule a free consultation or DM us **'BUYGUIDE'** on social media to connect with a Conejo Valley buyer specialist.

This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute financial, legal, or real estate advice. Market data is sourced from Zillow, Houzeo, the California Association of Realtors, Rocket Mortgage, and CalcLogix as of early 2026 and is subject to change. Always consult with qualified professionals before making purchasing decisions. MasterKey is a licensed real estate brokerage in California.